

Neville Island brings in business, loses industrial image

By Bonnie Pfister
TRIBUNE-REVIEW
Thursday, August 14, 2008

The opening this week of a four-story hotel on Neville Island is a signal of changing times for a community long known for industrial pollution.

At least that's what local leaders hope, as they work to bring different kinds of development to the five-mile sliver of land in the Ohio River.

"The perception is slowly changing," said Bill Easton, an officer with Neville Island Development Association, showing off a tranquil riverfront patio behind the 110-room Fairfield Inn & Suites at the corner of Interstate 79 and Grand Avenue. "People are using the river more and are starting to realize as they come here and spend a little more time that we're going from brown to green."

A nearby sign promotes a future King's Family Restaurant. A Subway sandwich shop opened in the past year. In June, Allegheny County officials announced plans to redevelop 78-acre Montour Junction across the river into public sports fields, with the popular Montour Trail to be extended across it.

Heavy industry will remain a part of Neville Island life, community leaders say. Once verdant farmland that produced asparagus and strawberries enjoyed in fine restaurants as far away as New York City, the land was transformed by war production in the early 20th century.

The southern third of the island remains home to thriving metal recyclers of appliances and autos, as well as Calgon Carbon Corp., Neville Chemical Co. and the Shenango Coke Works, visible from across the river for the orange balls of fire that periodically erupt from a chimney.

Groundwater testing is ongoing at the 30-acre site where a Gulf Oil refinery operated through the 1950s, but state and county environmental officials say the island's air and soil quality complies with legal standards.

"Neville Island continues to have its environmental scars from years of industry use, but a great deal of work has been done and dollars invested to reclaim the island over the years," said Neil Weaver, spokesman for the state Department of Environmental Protection.

Other development, however, is putting a new face on Neville. About eight years ago, FedEx Ground opened a facility in the industrial area. Easton and his colleagues are seeking other businesses to make use of "flex space" in former or new warehouses for office, commercial and manufacturing work.

But the biggest change to the island's profile and a major business boost has come from the Robert Morris University's Island Sports Center, occupying 32 acres of a former Superfund site on the island's northern tip.

In the mid-1990s, before it became a university, the Moon college sought to expand its athletic programs, said Dave Hanson, general manager of the sports complex, and former staffer of The Hillman Co., which originally owned the land. Leveling Western Pennsylvania's notoriously hilly landscape, however, adds dramatically to development costs. That turned out to be a point in Neville's favor.

"Right off the bat, we had land that is flat, which is pretty hard to find in Pittsburgh," said Hanson, who played one of the Hanson brothers in the 1977 cult classic "Slap Shot," starring Paul Newman.

The complex opened in 1998 as a public skating venue, featuring children's lessons as well as a home base for figure skating, in-line hockey and ice hockey clubs for local high schools and Robert Morris' intramural hockey leagues. It has an indoor golf driving range and a health club.

Robert Morris purchased the complex for \$10 million in 2003 -- the same year it launched the region's only NCAA Division 1 men's ice hockey league. A women's team was created a year later.

Robert Morris since has built fields for lacrosse, hockey and track, helping to fuel the university's booming student recruitment. That, in turn, is bringing more traffic to the sports center for such events as the 2005 World Street Hockey Championships, which drew participants and families from Europe, Canada and the Caribbean. About 700,000 people attended events last year.

"We've become a huge attraction to this part of Pittsburgh," Hanson said.

Raleigh-based Concord Hospitality took note. The owner of Fairfield Inn & Suites counts 350 businesses in the I-79 and Route 65 corridor, said spokesman Kevin McAteer.

Coupled with traffic generated by the growing university and nearby Sewickley Valley Hospital, he said, "it's an outstanding location due to its excellent visibility and the immediate access from I-79."

Beaver County businesswoman Lynn Saunier, too, is enjoying opportunities on the island -- and capitalizing on riverfront that was once the province of industrial barges.

She and her husband purchased a long-standing bowling alley near the sports complex in 2002, doubling its size and modernizing it in 2006. They created a sandy beachfront with tables and a cabana bar shaded by the island's naturally lush greenery, providing overflow from the restaurant and bar inside.

"On Fridays and Saturdays, we have people waiting up to two hours to get on a lane," Saunier said. "We do very well there."